

[Return to Search](#)

Original Page: 19

Culture (OWC): [Gusii \(FL08\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Eastern Africa

Field Date: 1946-1949

Coverage Date: Not Specified

Place Coverage

Nyanza Province, Southwestern Kenya, East Africa

Section Title(S): THE SECLUSION PERIOD

As a prelude to the mysteries proper, novices are subjected to a painful process which is said to be partly medicinal in its object. After nightfall boys bring in specially prepared ash of certain leaves and a quantity of warm water. The novices are told to wash their wounds and then to stand very erect, backs to the wall, and shut their eyes. Now the 'tamer' catches the penis firmly in a leaf, the inside of which has been coated with a paste of leaf-ash and water. The ash is caustic; the resulting pain is 'a really nasty one', making the novice cry out in agony. The Gusii believe that this painful application promotes clean healing.²

752
[Bodily Injuries](#)

881
[Puberty And Initiation](#)

The mysteries which are now administered consist in nothing more than forcing the novice to eat bitter or otherwise unpleasant substances, which are presented under the names of delicacies such as boys love. A novice may have had from his sponsor or other boys some vague general warning ('Don't eat all you are given'), but secrecy as to details is rigidly kept before-hand. The procedure is broadly as follows:

262
[Diet](#)

824
[Ethnobotany](#)

881
[Puberty And Initiation](#)

(1) *Riuga*, 'the bone'. 'Here is something to chew. It is a bone of So-and-so [naming one of the novice's father's cattle]. Your father slaughtered it. Your mother kept it for you to have after circumcision. Eat the meat that is sticking to the bone.' This, instead of being a marrow bone such as boys break and suck, is a root of the wild plant *omonyaigena*, with a bitter stinging taste.

(2) *Ritana*, 'the breast' — a favourite portion of meat. This 'fine fat meat' is a piece of the root of the *omonyankene* (a plant named after *enkene*, 'tapeworm segment', which its flowers are supposed to resemble). In small quantities it acts as a purgative, in larger quantities as a poison.

(3) *Omoongora*, 'fresh eleusine grain', cleaned but not yet dried, and sweet to chew. This turns out to be the berries of *omonyaigena*, which burns the mouth and stomach.

(4) *Omokano*, 'simsim', turns out to be a kind of wild fruit that burns.

K. told me: 'Others had warned me not to eat everything that would be offered. "Pretend to eat, but hide some of it!" I scraped at the food with my fingers. The next day I had blisters under the nails.' However, the lads are on the watch for such tricks, and push the unpleasant things down the novice's throat. As he chokes and splutters, they laugh and shout, and beat him with sticks torn from the bower: 'Eat, eat, you *omoisia* [uncircumcised boy]!' To cry at this stage carries no disgrace comparable to that of flinching during circumcision. The novice is lucky if he escapes with swollen, blistered lips and a painful mouth and tongue; many are said to develop severe stomach pains and to vomit, though I never heard of serious illness ensuing. These boyish practical jokes — as we might regard them — complete the first group  20 of the mysteries. After them there is usually an interlude while the lads introduce a device familiar to all students of initiation ceremonies — the bull-roarer, The Gusii know two kinds; whether one kind or both will be used, and whether immediately after the first mysteries or on a subsequent night, depends on the individual sponsor. One or two informants seemed to regard the bull-roarer as one of the mysteries, but this was contrary to the general view. Certainly it is not expected to terrify the novices seriously. In fact, I was told that the best thing is to introduce it as soon as possible after the mysteries, so as to entertain and distract from the pain.

262

Diet

534

Musical Instruments

881

Puberty And Initiation

²One young informant likened it to iodine.

Human Relations Area Files

755 Prospect Street

New Haven, CT 06511

General Inquiries:  hraf@yale.edu

Issues and Bugs:  hraf-support@yale.edu



[Terms and Conditions](#) · [Accessibility](#) · [Cookie Policy](#)